

Module 1:

The Meanings and Practices of Culture

Learning Outcomes

After complete this module, students should be able to:

- Discuss the concept of culture and its various components and characteristics
- Identify how one's own cultural perspectives and beliefs impact their understandings and positive interactions with other cultures
- Appreciate diverse dimensions of culture and explain their impacts on intercultural communication

Module Topics

Key topics covered in this module include:

1. Understanding Culture
2. Cultural Perspectives
3. Intercultural Communication Ethics

Module Overview

Important concepts that are covered in this module include:

- **Culture:**
In order to comprehend the intricacies involved in intercultural communication and interactions, it is important to have an understanding of what culture is. The definition of culture as provided by Liu, Volčič, & Gallois (2011) is a starting point from which to work: "Culture is the particular way of life of a group of people, comprising the deposit of knowledge, experience, beliefs, values, traditions, religion, notions of time, roles, spatial relations, worldviews, material objects, and geographic territory" (p. 57). Certainly, this definition is all-encompassing and reveals how pervasive culture is. By learning about the characteristics (Ch. 3) and dimensions (Ch.5) of culture, you will be better equipped to reflect upon how your own cultural perspective influences the way you see the world and your interactions with others. The aspects of culture described in these chapters showcase potential distinctions between cultures and reveal how behaviours can be understood in different ways. By recognizing this, it is possible to more accurately interpret the behaviour and statements of others, thus minimizing intercultural miscommunications.
- **Barriers to effective intercultural communication:**
Issues of ethnocentrism, stereotyping, prejudice, and racism (Ch. 4) can impact intercultural interactions and communication. It is helpful to be aware of such issues and to understand

how and why they arise in order to reduce intercultural conflict.

- **Intercultural communication ethics:**

The notion of ethics is significant to the discussion of intercultural communication as it encourages those involved to consider the perspectives of those with whom they are communicating. While the ethical principles discussed (Ch. 5) may seem to be based on simple common sense, they provide a foundation for core competencies that are required for intercultural communication.

Summary

This module attempts to lay the foundation for the Global Organizations and Cultural Perspectives course by encouraging you to consider what culture is and the various factors that impact it. The ways that culture is enacted in daily life affect how individuals manage their own life contexts and shape their interactions with others. It is important for you to reflect on how you are situated within your own cultural contexts and to consider how those cultural perspectives influence the ways that you behave and interact with the world around you. Reflecting in this way will enable you, as a global citizen, to consider how other individuals are also impacted by their own cultures. This will help you to better comprehend the importance of intercultural understanding in communication in your future work environment.

Questions for Consideration

- What is your understanding of culture?
- How do your own cultural perspectives influence your understanding of other cultures?
- Explain the importance of intercultural understanding for your current work context.
- How can ethnocentrism affect intercultural communication?
- Describe the organizational culture of your ideal workplace. What would it be like?